INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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CHAPTER 66

The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups

Ted A. Henken

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Abstract

Cuba's famed *paquete* has been celebrated in recent years for effectively undermining the Cuban government's historic media monopoly as it erupted in an offline digital response to the rising demand for more diverse and less ideologically charged media content. However, the *paquete*'s different compilers and distributors have also systematically practiced self-censorship in exchange for continued state tolerance of their growing *alegal* media enterprise by refusing to distribute political content, especially if it is critical of the government and/or produced by any of the independent digital media start-ups operating on the island today. This article analyzes this phenomenon by comparing the *paquete* to its two offline digital competi-

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tors: the government-sanctioned Mi Mochila, distributed via its network of Joven Clubs de Computación y Electrónica (JCCEs), and the clandestine, politically charged, "sneakernet" complement to the *paquete*, known as the *paketito*. The article concludes by highlighting the various ways the founding directors of a number of Cuba's leading independent digital media outlets solve the problem of the *paquete*'s self-censorship by developing an array of content-distribution strategies to fit Cuba's hybrid online-offline digital media environment.

Resumen

El famoso "paquete semanal" de Cuba se ha celebrado en los últimos años por socavar de manera efectiva el histórico monopolio mediático del gobierno cubano al irrumpir en una respuesta digital *offline* a la creciente demanda de contenido multimedia más diversa y menos cargada ideológicamente. Sin embargo, los diferentes compiladores y distribuidores del llamado paquete también han practicado sistemáticamente la autocensura a cambio de la continua tolerancia estatal de su creciente empresa de medios "alegal" al negarse a distribuir contenido político, especialmente si está crítico con el gobierno y/o producido por cualquiera de los nuevos *start-ups* de medios digitales independientes que operan en la Isla hoy. Este artículo analiza este fenómeno al comparar el paquete con sus dos competidores digitales *offline*: Mi Mochila, sancionada por el gobierno y distribuida a través de su red de Joven Clubs de Computación y Electrónica (JCCE), y el clandestino y políticamente cargado complemento al paquete, un "sneakernet" conocido como "el paketito." El artículo concluye destacando las diversas formas en que los directores fundadores de varios de los principales medios de comunicación digitales independientes de Cuba resuelven el problema de la autocensura del paquete al desarrollar una serie de estrategias de distribución de contenido únicas para adaptarse al entorno híbrido de medios digitales *online-offline* de Cuba.

> The Cuban government clearly tolerates *el paquete*. Even if officials are not being paid off, it satisfies many consumers, making them less likely to press for open Internet access. Had he been writing today, Karl Marx would have said "*el paquete* is the opium of the masses."
>
> —Larry Press, *The Internet in Cuba* (blog), September 14, 2015

Cuba's home-grown "sneakernet," colloquially known as *el paquete semanal*, or the weekly package, is an offline, islandwide digital data distribution network that rides on the back of hundreds of thousands of tiny flash drives and external hard drives.[1] The *paquete* has been rightly credited with (and often celebrated for) fundamentally undermining the Cuban government's long-standing monopoly over the mass media available to the Cuban public on

[1] The term *sneakernet* connotes bothe fact that this network — like its cousins in various developing and authoritarian countries around the world — circulates offline and is powered by human feet in proverbial "sneakers," and the fact that the existence of such networks, even when tolerated by the authorities, often includes a generous dollop of cloak-and-dagger clandestineness, that is, sneaking around at the margins of legality. Thus, although the *paquete* is not legal, neither is it clearly illegal. Cubans often describe it with the ironic term *alegal*, or "unlegal." While the *paquete* has benefited from this in-between legal status in the form of a begrudging government tolerance, this is predicated on a kind of sword-of-Damocles observance of unwritten rules on content. And unlike defensible legal rights, official tolerance can be extended or revoked arbitrarily.

the island. However, while the *paquete*'s various *paqueteros* or distributors (working in tandem with one of the island's four main *casas matrices* or compilation houses) have indeed successfully won over a Cuban public hungry for a more diverse, higher-quality, and less ideologically charged selection of commercial, technological, and especially entertainment-oriented content, they have also systematically refused to include in their offerings any programming they deem even remotely "political." This is especially the case if that content is critical of the Cuban government, its policies, or its leaders, and even more so if it is produced by the emergent crop of independent digital media outlets operating on the island today. [2]

This self-censorship—what might be called an internal blockade against independent locally produced political news (deployed not by state censors but also by Cuba's private, "alegal" *paqueteros* and *casas matrices* no less)—has especially affected the offline availability of the content of the more critical-minded digital media start-ups that practice investigative, watchdog, or adversarial journalism. These include *El Toque*, *El Estornudo*, and *14ymedio*, each of which has been forced to develop multifaceted content-distribution strategies that attempt to go far beyond *el paquete*. In contrast, Cuba's *paqueteros* have extended much different treatment to the handful of independent digital lifestyle, cultural, sports, and entertainment magazines that have appeared on the island in recent years. As a rule, almost all of these have paid for, depended on, and even been built around an offline, "direct-to-*paquete*" digital-distribution model. These include the sports magazine *Play-Off*, the fashion magazine *Garbos*, the start-up business magazine *Negolution*, and most prominently, Cuba's premier and pioneering independent entertainment, cultural, and celebrity lifestyle magazine *Vistar*.

Given this complex, contradictory, and dynamic state of affairs, this article begins with a brief description of the history and development of *el paquete*, linking its initial appearance and eventual shift toward self-censorship of political news to the emergence of its two main sneakernet competitors: the low-cost, government-produced Mi Mochila, a compendium of digital content distributed exclusively via its network of Joven Clubs de Computación y Electrónica (JCCEs) and the clandestine *paketito* (sometimes referred to as *el paketiko* or *el paketico*), a free weekly cache of digital content compiled and distributed by anonymous activists working to make publicly available the very thing that both the government media and mainstream *paqueteros* censor: independent, critical-minded journalism, some of which is produced by digital media start-ups operating in Cuba today. The concluding section of the article critically compares the various content-distribution strategies of some of these independent digital-media start-ups. Based on a questionnaire circulated among these start-ups' founding directors, the analysis centers on how they seek to solve the problem of the *paquete*'s self-censorship by developing an array of content-distribution strategies to fit Cuba's hybrid online-offline digital media environment. [3]

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[2] The *paquete* assiduously avoids politics and focuses mainly on entertainment, lifestyle, technology, and culture (broadly defined), but it does regularly contain digital versions of daily newspapers and magazines published by the Cuban Communist Party or Cuba's official mass organizations (virtually the only legally sanctioned publishers of printed material on the island). These include *Granma*, *Juventud Rebelde*, *Orbe*, and *Trabajadores*. Also, some of the independent magazines included in the *paquete* occasionally publish individual articles and even entire special editions of a political, pro-regime bent. *Vistar*'s December 1, 2016, special edition honoring Fidel Castro's legacy is perhaps the most notable example (see https://vistarmagazine.com/vistar-magazine-edicion-especial/).

[3] The author circulated a questionnaire among the founding directors of more than a dozen independent digital media start-ups, nearly all of which were launched in Cuba between 2014 and 2019, and nearly all of whom

Three-Way Sneakernet Throwdown: The Taming (and Contaminating) of *El Paquete*

While many foreign journalists have placed the emergence of the *paquete* around the year 2014, this offline digital combo clearly existed in various forms much earlier to that. We know this because it was in 2014 that the Cuban government—and especially its cultural officials—began to publicly confront the implications of the emergence and wide popular adoption of the paquete for its hallowed revolutionary *política cultural* (cultural policy) and its long-standing, but now clearly eroding, monopoly over Cuban mass media. It was also in mid-2014 that the government launched its first, abortive effort to produce an institutional response to the *paquete* in the form of the competing digital compilation known as Mi Mochila, addressed in greater detail here. Aimed at sounding out a wide group of writers and intellectuals who work in various state cultural institutions (the Cuban Writers' and Artists' Union, or UNEAC; the Hermanos Saíz Association, or AHS; and the Cuban Film Institute, or ICAIC), the government's cultural apparatus organized "Forum of Cultural Consumption in Cuba: Art, Culture, Education, and Technology," the weekend of October 31–November 1, 2014, at Pabellón Cuba in Havana's central La Rampa district. Headlined by former minister of culture Abel Prieto, then a special adviser to President Raúl Castro, the event was an opportunity for participants to reflect on "the impact the technological revolution has" on the changing "habits of cultural production and consumption," according to the state newspaper *Juventud Rebelde* (Bedevia 2014; *Diario de Cuba* 2014a).

In their remarks, Prieto and other high-placed government officials shared their growing alarm over the negative impacts of both violent video games and the spate of shallow, consumerist entertainment that dominates the *paquete* on the revolutionary values of Cuba's youth. "We cannot exhort our youth to develop a criminal instinct," Prieto insisted in relation to the growing craze among Cuban youth to play competitive multiplayer video games: "Some are inoffensive, but others are essentially violent and have converted into an addiction." In specific reference to the *paquete*, Prieto argued that it slyly gives its users the false "impression that one is choosing what to consume," when in fact it is the *paquete*'s compilers who have already curated a set of options that it "imposes on them," offering the compilation disingenuously as a portal of digital freedom (*Diario de Cuba* 2014a). "Democracy and diversity are hidden under a trick of the hegemonic agenda of entertainment," declared Prieto (Bedevia 2014), seemingly blind to the cynicism of such as statement—however on target it might be

responded. The questionnaire included eight questions related to strategies of distribution for reaching the on-island Cuban public; measurement and demography of the audience; attempts to place content in *el paquete* and/or *el paketito*; opinions about the quality and credibility of the content of the *el paquete*, *el paketito*, and *Mi Mochila*; and assessments of the future of offline data-distribution networks such as *el paquete* as the number, variety, speed, and quality of paid public online access points increases.

Those who responded on the record or on background (not for attribution) to all or part of the questionnaire include José Jasán Nieves Cárdenas of *El Toque* (2013), Yoani Sánchez of *14ymedio* (2014), Elaine Díaz of *Periodismo de Barrio* (2015), Abraham Jiménez Enoa of *El Estornudo* (2016), Maykel González of *Tremenda Nota* (2017), Bárbara Maseda of *Inventario* (2018), Robin Pedraja of *Visitar* Magazine (2014), Pedro Enrique Rodríguez Uz of *Play-Off* magazine (2015), Rebeca Alderete of *Garbos* magazine (2015), an editor at *Negolution* magazine (2016), an editor at *Hypermedia* magazine (2016), Carlos Alberto Pérez of the blog *La Chiringa de Cuba* (2010), and the independent filmmaker and former organizer of the *Paquete Semanal Autónomo* (PaSA, 2014) Yaima Pardo. One final respondent, who is active in the creation and distribution of el paketito and who is identified with the pseudonym "Juliana" here, wished to remain anonymous.

about the motivations driving the Western capitalist entertainment industry—coming from a representative of a government that has systematically—indeed, hegemonically—controlled the content available to the Cuban public through television, film, radio, and the press for decades, to say nothing of its monopolization of access to the internet on the island (*Diario de Cuba* 2014a).

Shifting the discussion to a potential institutional response to this cultural "crisis," Prieto obliquely suggested that attendees think of strategies whereby "a more diverse and inclusive *paquete* could be developed" (Bedevia 2014). "Up to what point should public spaces have some kind of regulation regarding what [media] is included," Prieto asked rhetorically, reminding his listeners that the government was not about to cede its hard-won control over Cuba's cultural policy to the private sector. The island is overflowing with initiatives, warned Prieto, "that have nothing to do with what we ourselves are aiming at" (*Diario de Cuba* 2014a). This line of argument led to a wide-ranging discussion by various attendees about ways the *paquete* could be "contaminated," "intervened," or successfully "invaded" with other, richer content, given the fact evident to all attendees that it certainly could not, and perhaps should not, be eliminated.

Indeed, Helmo Hernández, the longtime president of Cuba's Fundación Ludwig (FLC), which promotes the appreciation of Cuban art and culture, openly declared that, like it or not, the *paquete* is "the clearest expression of contemporary Cuban culture. It's what the people in the country like [to consume]." Given this fact, he argued that it was pointless to rail against the *paquete* or try to beat it at its own offline game. Instead, he suggested that government cultural institutions look for ways to add their own content to the *paquete* as a way of "contaminating" it with content of greater aesthetic value—something he said FLC had already started to do on an experimental basis (*Diario de Cuba* 2014b).[4]

The state-led regulatory reaction to the proliferation of the *paquete*, however, is only one side of the story. Additionally, as the *paquete* gradually became more lucrative for its compilers, entrenched in Cuban life, and won greater tolerance from the state for its increasingly systematic self-censorship of critical political content, some of its users began to revolt against its evermore "domesticated" and "cowardly" character. In fact, the independent journalist Luz Escobar published an article in *14ymedio* based on interviews with longtime consumers of the *paquete* during the month following Fidel Castro's death in late November 2016. Entitled "'The *paquete*' between two fires," the article reports that although *paquete* compilers had to exercise extreme caution regarding their content selection during this period so as not to inadvertently insult the memory of the deceased leader and provoke a state backlash, they simultaneously came under attack from users who were discontinuing their subscriptions given that the more controversial, interesting, and hard-hitting material they had once counted on was no longer there. Indeed, one couple interviewed by Escobar said they had decided to give up on the *paquete* and install an illegal satellite dish on their roof so they could regularly see Miami's Spanish-language news shows and television programs, which were no longer

[4] According to Isbel Díaz Torres, this "contamination" strategy has also been employed by many Cuban artists who have sought to use the *paquete* as a way to call attention to their work, whether painting, film, music, or art criticism. Díaz Torres notes that this strategy was particularly common during Havana's 2017 Bienal (personal communication, July 17, 2019). Also see Michael Levine's contribution to this dossier for an in-depth study of how controversial *reggaetoneros* use the paquete to distribute their music.

included in the *paquete*. It has "become annoying," they told her. "It has become as controlled as the [state run] Cubavisión channel" (Escobar 2016).

In an interview conducted in June 2019 via Facebook Messenger with an anonymous source in Cuba who has long been involved in compiling and distributing the more clandestine alternative to the *paquete* known as the *paketito*, "Juliana" (a pseudonym) outlined a clear, if gradual, shift in the content available to the public via the *paquete*. Hard news focused on Cuba and even satire of a politically critical nature gave way to light entertainment as a result of stepped-up pressure from state security on the *paquete*'s various *casas matrices*.

> The *paquete* initially emerged as a great compendium of digital data aimed primarily at entertainment, but which also included humorous programs that criticized the Cuban government and also news from Cuba and the world that was obtained by foreign media. However, when the weekly "package" became more popular than Cuban television, the political police began to exert psychological pressure on the main people in charge of forming the *paquete*, so that they eliminated critical content that mocked the revolution and its leaders. From that moment, the creators and distributors of the weekly package began to practice self-censorship. [5]

Juliana went on to specify that this "tipping point" became most evident in the summer of 2016, perhaps as a result of the biting political satire of Miami-based Cuban humorists like Carlos Otero and Alexis Valdés, who were especially adept at skewering Cuba's newfound fascination with the "miracle plant" moringa, which had been enthusiastically celebrated by Fidel Castro himself in recent memory. However, Juliana insists that there was no single show or critical article included in the *paquete* that set Cuba's censors off. Instead, she attributes the shift to the cumulative effect of the *paquete*'s growing popularity at the expense of the formerly hegemonic state media and the occasional appearance of critical material on the *paquete* that made a mockery of the Cuban regime and its leaders.

Mi Mochila: If You Can't Beat 'Em . . .

Going a step beyond the suggestion that state institutions should try to "contaminate" the *paquete* with material of a higher cultural, intellectual, or aesthetic order, in fits and starts between July 2014 and December 2016 the government made what turned out to be an initial abortive attempt to launch its own institutional version of the *paquete* (Arcos Fernández-Britto 2014). Called Mi Mochila, this digital compendium would be distributed via a pilot project that initially included just thirty-five of the UJC's network of more than six hundred JCCEs (Bosch Taquechel 2015). A large, perhaps unwieldy group of state institutes, associations, and foundations participated in the production and/or selection of Mi Mochila's weekly contents, including the Cuban Book Institute, the ICRT (Cuban Radio and Television Institute), ICAIC (Cuban Film Institute), Fundación Ludwig, the Cuban Music Institute, and the National Library (Palma 2015). Mi Mochila would also differ from the *paquete* in its decidedly more didactic and

[5] This quote is from the author's interview with Juliana conducted via Facebook Messenger during June 2019. Original Spanish: "El paquete, inicialmente surgió como un gran compendio de información dirigida al entretenimiento pero incluía programas humorísticos que criticaban al gobierno cubano y también noticias de Cuba y el mundo que era obtenida por medios de comunicación extranjeros. Cuando 'el paquete' semanal se hizo mas popular que la televisión cubana, entonces la policía política ejerció presiones psicológicas sobre los principales encargados de con- formar dicho paquete, para que eliminaran de dicho paquete los contenidos de crítica o burla a la revolución y a sus lideres. Desde ese momento los creadores y distribuidores del paquete semanal se auto censuran."

proudly "revolutionary" content and its (free) price. However, during its pilot phase between 2014 and 2016, Mi Mochila was normally far smaller than the *paquete* (300 to 350 gigabytes versus 900 gigabytes to 1 terabyte), less reliable as a weekly compendium (there were only fifteen "weekly" editions during its first year of existence), and much less popular (one JCCE reported just sixty-seven downloads during Mi Mochila's first six months of availability), characteristics that earned it the nickname *el anti-paquete* and *el paquete oficialista* at the time (Palma 2015). In other words, this was *not* a Cuban version of PBS or the BBC!

One of the key goals of the Mi Mochila project has been to prioritize "Cuban" cultural content over the foreign entertainment that predominates in the *paquete*—making it "bien cubana" (very Cuban) in the words of a 2017 issue of *Pionero*, a state-run magazine for Cuban adolescents. There has also been a strong emphasis on what might be called "family and revolutionary values" in Mi Mochila's digital content, given the criticisms lodged against the *paquete*'s supposedly "banal" and "vulgar" (chabacanería) offerings (Labacena Romero 2014). Indeed, the official page describing Mi Mochila at Ecured, Cuba's government-controlled Wikipedia clone, describes the project's objectives in three brief bullet points:

- "To satisfy the tastes and interests of different Cuban publics,
- [To distribute materials] that correspond with the principles and values promoted by the Cuban State, [and]
- To divulge Cuban culture and secure our national identity."[6] (*Ecured* 2019)

The project's initial logo was a simple backpack with the word *mochila* underneath it. Under that, in smaller type, are the words "para la familia" (for the family). Later, when the project was relaunched in December 2016 after a faulty start, it had a much more attractive graphic interface featuring a photo of a young Afro-Cuban mother smiling in the right foreground while pointing across her chest to the thirteen color-coded and graphically distinct categories of folders included in the compendium. This richly colorful design is augmented by a subtle but powerful image of two smiling Afro-Cuban children in the background who are not readily evident at first glance, because their images have been washed out so they fade into the graphic's deep purple foundation (Figure 1).

During the first two to three years of its five-year existence, the JCCE's Mi Mochila project had no distribution strategy other than allowing interested users to stop in to their local youth club and download all or part of the latest edition of the Mochila onto their personal flash drive. Similarly, during this period there was no publicity other than signs hung outside some of the clubs announcing the project's availability at that site (González 2014; Palma 2015; Bosch Taquechel 2015). This lethargy seemed to change in the early months of 2017, after the project was rebooted in December 2016 following the death of Fidel Castro. On December 30 of that year, a special issue of Mi Mochila dedicated to the life and legacy of the deceased leader was released (Ecured 2019; Martínez Hernández 2016; *14ymedio* 2016). Then, starting in 2017 it became possible to theoretically access and download the contents of Mi Mochila online via Cuba's intranet (though reports have noted that limited bandwidth

[6] Original Spanish: "*satisfagan los gustos e intereses de los diferentes públicos cubanos,*se correspondan con los principios y valores que promueve el Estado Cubano, *divulgue la cultura cubana y afiance nuestra identidad nacional."

and spotty and expensive internet access have made this option difficult to take advantage of) (Valdés González 2018).[7] Later, in April 2018, the JCCEs announced they were implementing a content-delivery service for the first time (perhaps in an effort to match the *paquete*'s



FIGURE 1. 'Mochila . . . for the family,' screenshot of Mi Mochila graphic interface, circa December 2016

popular home hand-delivery distribution method). However, using this service would cost users 10 Cuban pesos per delivery (*D-Cuba.com* 2018; *CiberCuba* 2018).

The Ecured page dedicated to the project repeatedly describes Mi Mochila as an "alternative of audiovisual entertainment," but never directly states the obvious—that it is intended to be an alternative to the much more popular and widespread *paquete* (Press 2015b). Given that much of its content comes from the same state cultural institutions that Cubans already have access to, the project cannot be meant as an alternative to that. Indeed, in a frank, if strangely worded, post on the University of Camagüey blog in September 2015, Alexei Nápoles celebrates the availability of the Mochila digital compilation to the university community because it "gives greater emphasis to topics of national interest" and features "cultural products of national provenance" serving "as a response to the *paquete semanal*, a ghost that separates us from our values and ideology but that exists and also reduces our boredom due to the lack of variety on National Television" (Nápoles 2015; *CiberCuba* 2018).

Expanding substantially on the three-point objective list above, the Mi Mochila Ecured page goes on to lay out a seven-point declaration of principles, including entertainment, versatility,

[7] Mi Mochila promoters also began to systematically present the digital compendium on popular Cuban TV shows like *La púpila asombrada*, on other shows aimed at teenagers and young people, on news programs such as *Buenos días*, and even on family TV shows like *De tarde en casa* (Isbel Díaz Torres, personal communication, July 17, 2019).

weekly distribution, flexibility, and feedback. However, the final two principles, "fidelity to the values that Cuban society promotes" and "moderation" are worth unpacking a bit more thoroughly. The principle of fidelity is glossed as having an undeniably political meaning: "attachment to the ethical and moral principles and values that underpin the revolutionary process." The principle of "moderation" is justified as a way to "avoid the reproduction of cultural and social stereotypes imposed by other media, alien to our values and aspirations; and that glorify and praise violence, alcoholism, the consumption of legal and illegal drugs, nudity and erotic-sexual scenes, among others" (Ecured 2019). The Cuban Communist Party never sounded more like the Family Research Council, the American fundamentalist Christian activist group.

In terms of specific content, the Mochila includes thirteen file categories, including video games, mobile and PC apps, continuing education materials, *De mi terruño* (a compendium of digital products originating in Cuba's provinces), *Estanquillo* (a digital newsstand that includes books and audiobooks, laws and other legal documents, dictionaries and encyclopedias, and copies of Cuba's principal state-run newspapers and magazines), *Me dicen Cuba* (a variety of audiovisual materials produced in Cuba including novels, TV shows, sprits, film, music, humor, children's shows, documentaries, and radio shows), and *Somos el mundo* (virtually the same variety of AV material as available in *Me dicen Cuba* but of international provenance). While the Cuba-centered character of the digital selection is to be expected, it is striking that no international Spanish-language newspapers or magazines are included in *Somos el mundo* to compliment the domestic, official-press-oriented *Estanquillo*.

When a number of the directors of Cuba's leading independent digital media start-ups were questioned about their take on the government strategy behind Mi Mochila and asked to compare the content of the Mochila to that of the *paquete* (Press 2015b), there was virtual unanimity that it was motivated by a wrongheaded and ideologically charged didactic strategy that would never appeal to more than a handful of users leading to a failed and arrogant effort to "elevate the level of aesthetic taste of the public" (Rodríguez Ramírez 2017). While Elaine Díaz, the founder of *Periodismo de Barrio*, was unable to respond to this question directly, she did post a meme on Facebook a few years ago making her assessment of the *Mochila* versus the *paquete* abundantly clear: "I don't want your *Mochila*. I want my *paquete*" (Figure 2).

El Paketito: Autonomous, Clandestine, and Unknown

People like Juliana, the clandestine compiler-distributor of *el paketito* introduced earlier, face a classic catch-22 in their effort to spread censored material as far and wide as possible within Cuba while also doing so discretely and only among a limited group of trusted friends so as to avoid government censure. Luz Escobar, the first Cuban journalist to publish a report on the *paketito*, recognized this dilemma. "The secrecy with which the *paketito* is put together," she observed, "affects the reach of its distribution, which has been restricted to clients as transgressive as its creators" (Escobar 2017).[8] The instinct to fiercely protect one's anonymity is certainly understandable in a context where strict laws intended to protect "state security"

[8] Original Spanish: "La clandestinidad con que se confecciona el paketito afecta la ampliación de su distribución, que se ha visto restringida a clientes tan transgresores como sus creadores."



FIGURE 1. 'Mochila . . . for the family,' screenshot of Mi Mochila graphic interface, circa December 2016.

can easily be used to arbitrarily target free speech activists. Indeed, in our very last exchange via Facebook Messenger about the *paketito*, Juliana reminded me:

> I believe that people like me who share these kinds of [censored] information "packages" must do so secretly, clandestinely, because in publishing about the [existence of] the *paketito* and showing our

> identity, we run the risk that the political police will accuse us of "spreading enemy propaganda," a crime against the security of the state [here in Cuba].[9]

While Juliana is confident that the *paketito* is more popular and widespread among the Cuban public than *Mi Mochila* (a project she considers to be nothing more than digital "brainwashing"), perhaps as a result of her need to keep a low profile and circulate the compendium only among a tight, trusted circle of friends, very few of the directors of the twelve to fifteen independent digital-media start-ups interviewed for this article had ever actively consumed or even heard of *el paketito*. In contrast, they had all heard of Mi Mochila, with many having sampled its contents at least once—which they universally found of little interest. Thus, while Elaine Díaz's humorous meme "I don't want your Mochila. I want my *paquete*" is intended as a backhanded retort to the government's launch of Mi Mochila as a didactic tool of political propaganda, an even more stinging meme could capture the dilemma faced by the *paketito*'s compliers: *No sé nada de tu paketito. Quiero mi paquete* (I've never even heard of your *paketito*. I want my *paquete).*

When asked to compare the distribution strategy and contents of the *paquete* to those of the *paketito*, *14ymedio* director Yoani Sánchez noted that each one suffered from drawbacks inherent to its public or clandestine character. "In the case of the *paquete*, there is very little news or informative coverage of Cuba," she notes. "The *paquete* is basically for fun, film debuts, soap operas, TV series, and software." She continued: "While it circulates among a much larger audience than the *paketito*, unlike this [clandestine] channel, the *paquete* avoids covering thorny topics because its distribution is very public and visible which also means that it can be very quickly censored. The *paketito* has a greater variety of materials about Cuba but still suffers from a lack of a stable regularity and an attractive assortment [of material]."[10]

Although the first public mention in print of *el paketito*'s existence as an organized information distribution project dates from May 5, 2017 (Escobar 2017), the goal of what has been called "breaking the Cuban government's information blockade" by engaging in the independent production and distribution of news and information is perhaps as old as the Cuban Revolution itself (Carey 2016). This is perhaps even more true of the independent circulation of data in the digital age since the ease of copying, concealing, and sharing such data have drastically increased as the cost has dropped to almost zero. It was with this awareness that Cuban television director and independent filmmaker Yaima Pardo dreamed up her own "Autonomous Weekly Package" project (*Paquete Semanal Autónomo*) in 2014. Known during its brief life by its Spanish acronym, *PaSA* (a play on the word *pass* or *pass along*), Pardo's idea arose quite independently of what would later emerge as the so-called *paketito* even though she would later regularly collaborate with the *paketito*'s compilers by providing them with a

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[9] Original Spanish: "Creo que las personas que compartimos este tipo de paquetes de información debemos hacerlo de forma secreta, clandestina pues de publicar sobre el paketito y mostrar nuestra identidad corremos el riesgo de que la policía política nos acuse del delito contra la seguridad del estado 'difundir propaganda enemiga.'"

[10] This quote is from Sánchez's response to the author's questionnaire, received from her on June 13, 2019. Original Spanish: "En el caso del Paquete hay muy pocas noticias o temas informativos sobre Cuba. [. . .] El Paquete es básicamente divertimento, películas de estreno, telenovelas, series y software . . . Llega a una audiencia mucho mayor que el Paketiko pero, a diferencia de este último, evita tocar temas espinosos porque su distribución es bastante pública y visible por lo que puede ser rápidamente censurada. El Paketiko tiene una mayor variedad de materiales sobre Cuba pero todavía adolece de una periodicidad estable y un surtido atractivo."

digital copy of each of her many documentary shorts to distribute freely to their subscribers (Risco 2014; Press 2014a):

> Yes, I've heard of the *paketito*. I think it's interesting to create an alternative to the self-censorship suffered by the *paquete semanal*. But in turn, I think that the *paketico* needs a structure. A network of people who share it systematically is essential to defend this initiative. I personally shared all my work with the *paketico* manager, but that kind of enterprise cannot be the responsibility of a single person.[11]

As a longtime subscriber to the *paquete*, over time Pardo had become acutely aware of the bitterly ironic fact that although the renegade sneakernet network had originally emerged as a way to circumvent state censorship, already by 2014 the *paquete*'s main distributors were beginning to filter out critical political content. As a creator of independent digital content herself, Pardo saw that others—especially those independent journalists who were doing pioneering investigative reporting in Cuba and about vital Cuban issues—were having their websites blocked by the government online while their digital content was being blocked offline by the *paquete*'s own censors. Aiming to disrupt this state of affairs, Pardo and her partners envisioned operating PaSA as a kind of "citizen's journalism report [where] people produce their own content with social objectives." Given that the *paquete* as it then existed satisfied neither her political curiosity nor her avant-garde artistic sensibility, she intended *PaSA* to be an offline grassroots digital community, "the kind of Internet we could create ourselves" if we had regular Internet access. She also faced the question of offline political censorship squarely, insisting that *PaSA* would include critical material considered taboo by the mainstream paquete, such as the independent digital newspaper *14ymedio*, which was launched only a few months prior to *PaSA* (Risco 2014). In the end, however, the *PaSA* project never got off the ground and Pardo ultimately immigrated to the United States where she currently lives.[12]

According to Escobar's 2017 article in *14ymedio*, "The '*paketito*,' a clandestine rival for the '*paquete*,'" began informally in early 2014 among a small group of friends who sought to fill the information gaps left by the more commercial, entertainment-oriented *paquete*. The weekly package had become far too comfortable and tame for their tastes, so they began to share archives and files among themselves with an emphasis on censored materials, documentaries, and news. Additionally, the compilers occasionally include old Cuban publications that had been forgotten or suppressed when what they originally reported in their pages later became politically inconvenient or embarrassing for the government. A case in point is a digital edition of the Cuban magazine *Bohemia* from 1959 in which Fidel Castro denies being a communist. During the *paketito*'s first few years of existence its producers often found it impossible to update their material with regularity, but they overcame this obstacle by early 2017, after which time the clandestine compendium became truly a weekly standard (Escobar 2017; San Martín and Cabrera 2017).

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[11] This quote is from Pardo's response to the author's questionnaire, received from her on June 19, 2019. Original Spanish: "Sí, he escuchado del paketito. Creo que es interesante crear un alternativa a la autocensura que sufre el paquete semanal. Pero a su vez considero que al "Paketico" le hace falta una estructura, una red de personas que lo compartan sistemáticamente es imprescindible para defender esta iniciativa. Yo personalmente le compartí todos mis trabajos al gestor del Paketico pero esa empresa no puede ser responsabilidad de una sola persona."

[12] Since immigrating, Pardo has become involved in the independent news site ADNCuba (Cuba DNA), launched in 2017 and blocked by the government in 2019.

The materials that are included in the always-free compilation are usually downloaded from YouTube or other popular social media sites by activists while traveling abroad. In years past, the total size of the *paketito* was usually no larger than five gigabytes; however, more recently the compendium has grown to between twelve and fifteen gigabytes of new material each week. Some materials come from those who have privileged access to high-speed internet access at certain state-sector jobs. A unique feature of the *paketito* relative to both the *paquete* and Mi Mochila is that it is easily "contaminated"; that is, the compilation is originally created with specific content, but its users often freely enrich it as it circulates from person to person. According to the independent journalist Joan Manuel Núñez Díaz (2017), the general rule dictating the content included in the *paketito* is exactly the inverse of the one that guides the *paquete*: "Although it's true that the authorities have managed to get the *paquete* to leave out the material they consider 'politically incorrect,' . . . the *paketito* has been conceived of to include exactly that."

Therefore, each week the compilation includes a file labeled "prensa escrita prohibida" (prohibited print media), which typically features recent articles from the Spain-based *Diario de Cuba*, Havana's *14ymedio*, and Miami's *Cubanet*. The musical selection also highlights groups known for political protest music that have been banned from stores and state media and are often prevented from performing live, such as the hip-hop duo Los Aldeanos and the punk rock group Porno para Ricardo. Finally, there is a recurring weekly section in the *paketito* reserved for news about Venezuela and another labeled "represión" in which videos and other news and information about human rights abuses in Cuba can be found (Escobar 2017). This quick inventory reveals that the *paketito* is indeed awash in political news and information either about Cuba or about Latin America, the very thing *paquete* compilers assiduously avoid.

While Juliana wished to remain anonymous, she did share the general profile of the various kinds of people involved in compiling and distributing the *paketito*. "Mainly, they are politically curious Cubans who avidly consume information," she explained. While the core group includes dissidents, activists, and independent journalists and artists, Juliana said that the *paketito*'s distributors and consumers also include *cuentapropista*s, college students, college professors, and practicing doctors. Juliana indicated that a typical week might include material from the nightly news broadcasts of Miami's *Radio y Televisión Martí* and Colombia's *NTN24*, as well as news clips or mini-documentaries from Spanish TV, Euronews, CNN, BBC Mundo, and the *Unreported World* program produced by Channel 4 in the United Kingdom. There is also typically print and video journalism from *Diario de Cuba*, *Cubanet*, and *Cibercuba*, a section of recent Spanish-language interviews with world leaders and Latin American newsmakers, the most recent videos from popular Cuban YouTubers like Liu Santiesteban, Alex Otaola, and Juan Juan Almeida, and digital copies of the popular talk shows hosted in Miami by Andrés Oppenheimer, Oscar Haza, and Jaime Bayly.

To provide greater insight into the *paketito*'s content, Juliana also provided a digital copy of the file structure and titles of all the video clips and news articles included in the June 20–25, 2019, edition of the *paketito*. In this particular compendium, there are 20 separate file folders with a total of 260 files, clocking in at 15.35 gigabytes of data. Perhaps the most striking thing about the collection is that all but 12 of the 260 files are MP4 videos. That is, the *paketito* is essentially a curated collection of television political news, opinion, and analysis downloaded each week from YouTube, where anyone with a fast-enough internet connec-

tion could locate and view the same content. The twelve text files are PDFs of print articles published by *Cubanet* (six), *Diario de Cuba* (five), and *14ymedio* (one). Thus, while part of the raison d'être of the *paketito* was supposedly to serve as a channel to domestically distribute journalism independently produced by Cubans who live in Cuba, the vast majority of its content is produced abroad and mostly not by Cubans.

Particularly striking were the twenty-one highly produced, deeply critical, and unapologetically obnoxious video rants from the Miami-based Cuban YouTuber Alex Otaola, who gleefully skewers a series of Cuban officials and cultural commissars. There are also file folders dedicated to documentaries and documentary series with the week's fare including the acclaimed HBO docudrama *Chernobyl* and an assortment of short docs produced by Deutsche Welle, including "How European Immigrants Populated the United States," "Rwanda: 25 Years Later," and "Climate Refugees: The Real Cost of Global Warming." The interview section includes face-to-faces with former Chilean president Michelle Bachelet (who recently visited strife-torn Venezuela); the director of Human Rights Watch Americas, José Miguel Vivanco; and a first-of-its-kind sit-down between Telemundo anchor José Díaz-Balart and President Donald Trump (subtitled in Spanish). There are also files containing sports videos (twenty-three), humor (four), animated political satire about Venezuelan president Nicolás Maduro (one), and the latest two episodes of a multipart video course on the cultural history of Cuba produced by Miami-Dade College and hosted by Professor Mercedes Cros Sandoval.

Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Independent Digital Media: "Tú no sales en 'el paquete'"

Just five days before launching *14ymedio*, her own long-anticipated independent digital daily newspaper on May 21, 2014, Cuba's best-known blogger Yoani Sánchez (2014a) published one of her classic day-in-the-life posts on her widely read blog *Generación Y*. With the eye-catching title, "Ah . . . tú no sales en 'el paquete'" (Ah . . . you've been left out of "the package"), her four-paragraph post chronicles a recent, overheated ride she took in one of Cuba's private collective taxis. Pressed in on all sides by sweaty bodies at high noon as the car lurched down the street with little success at avoiding its numerous potholes, she readied herself to endure the cabbie's inevitable choice of what she considered yet another misogynist reggaeton played at deafening volume. However, instead of disgust at the song's sexist lyrics, she found herself drawn to the apt sociological lesson embedded in its simple but penetrating refrain: "tú no sales en 'el paquete.'"

"The singer was mocking someone else," Sánchez explains, "and spit out the words 'Ah . . . you've been left out of 'the package,'" confident that such a hyperlocal, technological reference of recent vintage would be understood by all listeners as the hippest and most devastating of put-downs. The vocalist's barb was likely aimed at a rival musician whose music had not made the curator's cut and was thus not available to the mass national audience that had by then begun to use the *paquete* as a popular alternative to the far less raw and much more ideologically saturated programming found on state radio and television stations. To be "left out of the *paquete*," Sánchez notes, had already entered the popular Cuban lexicon as the equivalent of "uncool." "If a certain video, documentary, or film is left out of these compilations," she observes, "that's a sign it has little notoriety."

For Sánchez, this explains why state television programs such as the arch-official and über-square *Mesa Redonda* (roundtable) news analysis series was never included in these privately circulated digital combos at the time. They are the epitome of uncool. "The voice of the Cuban Communist Party," she concludes her post triumphantly, "has been left out of the '*paquete*' . . . for being boring, bland, repetitive . . . and for its lack of credibility" (Sánchez 2014a). The great irony, of course, is that—despite being one of its very earliest chroniclers, most enthusiastic boosters, regular users, and even an accidental contributor[13]—¡*Yoani tampoco sale en el paquete!* (Yoani isn't included in the package either!).[14]

Indeed, there are numerous reports even at this early date of its existence in 2014 that as *el paquete* became more formalized, centralized, and institutionalized into a structure of four national compilation houses (*casas matrices*), each presumably with its own growing financial interests and government oversight (if not direct control), its top-level compliers began to self-interestedly self-censor, wisely steering clear of politics, pornography, and religion (Díaz Torres 2014a, 2014b; Blumenthal and Wise 2015).[15] And while perhaps in 2014 the *paquete* would have been the last place you could find government news or propaganda, in later years its compilers have been quick to systematically include a file folder containing official Cuban magazines and daily newspapers—including *Granma*, "the voice of the Cuban Communist Party."

That the *paquete* not only blocks critical independent "political" voices like hers but also has come to regularly include (a small amount of) state propaganda in the form of official newspapers and magazines is not lost on Sánchez. It would have been impossible to distribute

[13] Although she did not use the term *paquete* at the time, Sánchez was among the first observers to write about the clandestine distribution of terabyte-sized caches of digital data in a *Huffington Post* blog post in October 2012. Sánchez has also chronicled how she and everyone who swaps digital files in Cuba becomes a potential contributor to the content of the *paquete*, because what they share can be shared by others innumerable times or even taken up by top-level compilers as part of the *paquete* itself (see Sánchez 2014b).

[14] This is not a dilemma faced only by notorious regime critics like Sánchez. Indeed, Harold Cárdenas (personal communication, July 18, 2019) one of the three founders of the critical- minded, independent, yet proudly revolutionary blog portal *La Joven Cuba* (*LJC*) noted that his publication experienced an unpredictable, uneven reception from the paquete's different *casas matrice*s. "*La Joven Cuba* for several years included successfully its PDF Magazine (https:// jovencuba.com/revista/) in one of [the *matrices*] and was rejected in others. Apparently, the perception of what is 'allowed' changes in time and *matrices*. We just started including recent magazines and received a warning from one of the organizers of *El Paquete* explaining that despite their own intentions, 'inappropriate content' is blocked, so we can only hope to be 'appropriate.'" More telling still was the follow-up message Cárdenas sent two weeks later on August 5: "Hi Ted, Things changed, I thought you might be interested," followed by a link to an article published at *LJC* two days earlier. The article, written by Dolores Ibárruri and facetiously entitled, "*LJC* in the Porn Industry," chronicles the magazine's unsuccessful attempt to break back into the *paquete* after having been included in it for a time, followed by a brief period where publication was suspended due to a lack of resources and content. Ibárruri had previously been told by a compiler friend after asking him what his content guidelines were: "Look, dear, except pornography and counterrevolutionary stuff, I include everything. I don't want any trouble. Don't you realize if I add any of that they'll shut down my business? I don't want any problems with anyone. I just quietly do my thing." However, in summer 2019, when Ibárruri returned to that same compiler to help facilitate *LJC*'s reentry, he sang quite a different tune. "Look, don't even mention those people," he declared. "I have instructions not to include anything from that magazine." Ibárruri protested, "Why? What's the problem?" Her *paquetero* friend responded emphatically: "I have no idea. But my answer is no. Some officials came to warn me about that and they told me not to do it." Frustrated with this cryptic, negative response to the inclusion of content from a source she considered to be anything but counterrevolutionary, Ibárruri sardonically concluded her article with the words, "I wish the people behind LJC much success in the X-rated film industry" (Ibárruri 2019).

[15] While some observers have claimed that *paquete* compliers assiduously steer clear of politics, porn, *and* religion, religion is in fact a very important part of *el paquete*'s offerings in some *matrices*, in particular the "Christian section" (Ibárruri 2019).

14ymedio via the *paquete* at the time she wrote, "Ah . . . tú no sales en 'el paquete,'" because the digital daily first appeared five days later. Still, eight months later, on February 9, 2015, she wrote admiringly on her blog about how the very use of the independent medium of the *paquete*—even if writing about topics like popular dance music, celebrity, or entrepreneurship that Cuba's cultural commissars may tolerate but also consider "banal" or "vulgar"—allows "readers to already imagine a different country Politics is not spoken of in any of their articles and nevertheless each text published is a negation of the ideology in power." [16] This is her celebratory assessment of the what we might call the "*paquete* effect" on its consumers, despite the fact that its compilers must—like the underground operators of Havana's various SNETs, or "street nets"—remain silent about politics and porn "as the rules of the game as a matter of survival": [17]

> Among its dozens of files filled with TV series and films, there's a handful of news stories and magazines. However, just one click is enough to show that few want to get in trouble with the government for distributing critical materials. Thus, the distributors . . . pay their toll by including copies of *Granma*, official news broadcasts, and offline versions of provincial papers. Still as they say in the movies, "hidden among the leaves, there are nuggets of gold." (Sánchez 2015) [18]

Hacks, Bypasses, and Work-Arounds [19]

Given the substantial political, economic, and logistical obstacles to Internet access in Cuba, a visitor to the island today might be surprised to find that most Cubans are not strangers to the worldwide digital revolution. This quote is from a Hypermedia editor's response to the author's questionnaire, received on June 6, 2019. Original Spanish: "La decisión parte del acceso limitado de los usuarios cubanos a Internet y a los servicios de mensajería telefónica. Estas limitaciones han convertido el e-mail en una de las vías de comunicación de mayor uso en la isla.". Far from it. Instead, they have invented multiple ways to get around government censorship and gain access to the vast digital content on the web without always having direct access to the web itself. Foreign journalists—especially those writing for US tech or business magazines who have visited Cuba in recent years to take the measure of the island's peculiar offline-online digital reality—have created a veritable cottage industry, writing pieces aimed at making sense of Cuba's upside-down Internet for their astonished, "always on" readers back home.

Perhaps the most eye-catching headline in this minigenre is Will Fulton's (2016) amusing piece in *Thrillist* entitled "Cuba's Internet is F*cking Insane: And the Ways Cubans Use It Are

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[16] Original Spanish: "[A]l leerlas ya está imaginando un país diferente. [. . .] No se habla de política en ninguno de sus artículos y sin embargo cada texto publicado es una negación de la ideología en el poder."

[17] Original Spanish: "aceptan tales pautas como una cuestión de sobrevivencia."

[18] Original Spanish: "Entre sus decenas de carpetas cargadas de series y películas, se cuelan algunas noticias y revistas. Un clic bastará para comprobar que pocos quieren meterse en problemas con el Gobierno por distribuir materiales críticos. De manera que los repartidores [. . .] pagan el peaje incluyendo copias del diario *Granma*, materiales del noticiero televisivo y salvaguardas de sitios digitales pertenecientes a periódicos provinciales. Pero . . . al decir de un personaje cinematográfico, 'entre la hojarasca brillan pepitas de oro.'"

[19] The strategies described here are reminiscent of the early days of the Internet in the United States when users connected to the internet using dial-up modems. Usenet News provided asynchronous, international threaded discussions of all sorts of technical, cultural, and political topics, and using e-mail to retrieve documents was common. For an early Cuban example of this, see Press (2014b).

Genius." There's also the provocatively titled burb from *Barrons*, "Popular Piracy: Cuba's New TV Network" (Blumenthal and Wice 2015), and the deep dives from *Forbes*, "No Internet? No Problem: Inside Cuba's Tech Revolution" (Helft 2015); *Wired*, "Inside Cuba's D. I. Y. Internet Revolution" (García Martínez 2017); and *PC Magazine*, "Black Markets and Secret Thumb Drives: How Cuban's Get Online" (Fenton 2016). What these digital snapshots of Cuba have in common is a collective amazement at the ingenious, home-grown hacks, bypasses, and work-arounds that Cubans have come up with to live—albeit often vicariously—in the digital age. Fenton's 2016 piece for *PC Magazine* captures this spirit with the words, "In my eight days on the island, I saw firsthand how ordinary Cubans jailbreak the World Wide Web using a combination of hacked apps, Wi-Fi extenders, and cached websites traded on hard drives. This is how Cuba gets online."

One popular work-around is using one's email account or SMS service as a proxy for web access by subscribing to e-mailed digests or feeds of news and information regularly sent out by popular websites like *14ymedio* and *Hypermedia Magazine*. This strategy allows users to use e-mail and text messages as proxies for fuller web access, a practical solution for Cuba given that e-mail access has long been far cheaper and thus more common and convenient for Cubans than access to the World Wide Web itself. An editor at *Hypermedia*, an independent digital Cuban art and culture magazine and book publisher based in Spain, explained that the magazine's recent decision to revamp its distribution strategy through sending out e-mail digests "arises from the limited access Cuban users have to the Internet and phone messaging services." According to him, "These limitations have converted e-mail into one of the most popular communication channels on the island."[20] Additionally, since at least 2014, Cubans with a Nauta e-mail address issued by the state telecom monopoly Etecsa have been able to configure their mobile phones so that they can receive messages sent to their addresses ending in "@nauta.cu" without having to have mobile Internet service, which did not become commercially available to the public until December 2018.

Another common strategy is to access blocked websites by using proxies or by subscribing to the weekly PDF digests that many Cuban media projects distribute to interested parties using flash drives passed from hand to hand. The rolling proxy strategy was used by Cuba's most popular classifieds site *Revolico* until it was unblocked in 2016 after eight years of playing cat-and-mouse with state censors (Fenton 2016; *CiberCuba* 2016). The indie digital media start-up *14ymedio*—which continues to be blocked by the government—systematically uses proxies to reach Cubans on the island, whom the publication considers its primary public. Indeed, *14ymedio*'s strategies of diffusion include a wide variety of platforms such as Telegram, WhatsApp, a weekly PDF news digest, and an e-mail bulletin similar to the one described by the *Hypermedia* editor. They also employ special digital tools such as virtual private networks (VPNs) and anonymous proxies (that hide the country of origin of the user from detection). Collectively, these work-around distribution strategies can be summed up with these words

[20] This quote is from a Hypermedia editor's response to the author's questionnaire, received on June 6, 2019. Original Spanish: "La decisión parte del acceso limitado de los usuarios cubanos a Internet y a los servicios de mensajería telefónica. Estas limitaciones han convertido el e-mail en una de las vías de comunicación de mayor uso en la isla."

from Sánchez: "[We aim to] make sure that our content is available to the largest number of readers on the island because the residents of Cuba are our principal reading public." [21]

El Estornudo, an independent digital publication started in March 2016 that specializes in long-form, narrative journalism, chronicles, opinion, and analysis has recently been forced to revamp its own distribution strategy given that it was blocked from online island access by the government starting in late-February 2018 (Álvarez 2018, 2019). "Access to the magazine, from the national territory, is impossible," explained Abraham Jiménez Enoa, one of the start-up's founding editors. "The government's decision to veto its access has forced us to rethink our distribution strategy and we decided to upload our content to the *Medium* platform too (which is not blocked), as well as to strengthen our presence on social networks." [22]

Additionally, many of Cuba's independent digital media start-ups have created their own pages or feeds on popular social media sites like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, WhatsApp, LinkedIn, and more recently Telegram, allowing readers in Cuba to follow them without their having to go directly to their websites, some of which are blocked from access on the island. For example, given that it has long been blocked from online island access, *14ymedio* has pioneered the distribution of its content via a WhatsApp subscription feed (thus circumventing the online-offline divide), and its director Yoani Sánchez records and uploads a ten-to twelve-minute daily "morning news show" available via both Facebook Live and YouTube called *Ventana 14*. The show began on December 10, 2018, the International Day of Human Rights, with the purpose of reviewing the coming day's news as covered in the virtual pages of *14ymedio*. Sánchez describes her "café informativo" as being like "a quick sip of coffee; intense and sometimes bitter, but necessary" (Sánchez 2018). Transforming YouTube into a podcasting platform is particularly ingenious because the government does not block that popular site even though access to the *14ymedio* site itself is blocked. Furthermore, the podcast is purposely set up on YouTube in an audio-only format so it can more easily be accessed by a bandwidth-poor island audience.

Others like *El Toque*, whose website is not blocked from access in Cuba but that is nonetheless censored by two of Havana's three main offline *paquete* compilation houses, have even recently designed their own apps that can function and be updated with new content offline via e-mail or text message without a connection to the web. José Jasán Nieves Cárdenas, *El Toque*'s director, explained his offline distribution strategy to reach the Cuban public on the island this way:

> We developed a mobile app that has the option of being updated *without* the need of having Internet, with a Nauta e-mail address, an Infomed e-mail address, or even a Gmail address if users prefer, [the app] can be updated [that way]. This means that using institutional networks, using Nauta, users can send us an e-mail and they will receive an [automatic] response from the application showing them our articles. [23]

[21] Original Spanish: "'lograr que nuestro contenido llegue a la mayor cantidad de lectores dentro de la Isla,' porque los residentes en Cuba son nuestro principal público lector."

[22] This quote is from Jiménez Enoa's response to the author's questionnaire, received from him on May 27, 2019. Original Spanish: "El acceso a la revista, desde territorio nacional, es imposible, pues el gobierno decidió vetar su acceso. Eso nos hizo replantearnos nuestra estrategia de difusión. Y decidimos subir nuestros contenidos también a la plataforma Medium (que no está bloqueada), además de fortalecer el trabajo en las redes sociales."

[23] This quote is from Nieves Cárdenas's response to the author's questionnaire, received from him on June 14, 2019. Original Spanish: "Nosotros desarrollamos una aplicación móvil que tiene la opción de actualizarse

Some innovative Cuban techies have even figured out ways to extend the reach of Etecsa's Wi-Fi hotspots using a "Nano" receptor or by piggybacking on gamers' local area networks (popularly known as the SNET) so that they and their friends can connect to hot-spot signals directly from their homes or offices (Press 2016). There are also a host of popular smartphone apps that allow for easy person-to-person sharing or quick downloading of digital content. One such app is Zapya, which uses smartphones' Bluetooth function to allow users to share data among a small, contiguous group of people. Then there are the apps Feedly and Pocket, which work in tandem, with the first set up to automatically download the news feeds of various preselected websites, and the second to allow users to save selected articles for later reading offline. These two apps are especially useful in Cuba's costly Wi-Fi hot-spot environment, as they allow users to maximize their bandwidth while minimizing their time (and thus money) spent online.

Finally, it is important to note that while the now-famous offline *paquete* sneakernet has become Cuba's default mass media, it was not the island's first offline distribution phenomenon, nor is it currently the only one. Indeed, there are many other informal ways of sharing digital information or channels of digital circulation and distribution of content that predate, go beyond, or in the words of Nieves Cárdenas "bypass" the *paquete*—especially when the news content is of high quality or particularly important or noteworthy, and when the *paquete* compilers won't touch it. Indeed, this was the case for what to date has likely been Cuba's most widely watched and perhaps first truly "viral" (and almost exclusively offline) video phenomenon: the University of Computer Science student Eliécer Ávila's biting, impertinent public questioning of the then president of Cuba's National Assembly Ricardo Alarcón, followed by Alarcón's widely mocked and patronizing answers (Press 2013). Although this episode took place on February 6, 2008, well before the formalization of the distribution networks that would eventually become known as *el paquete*, the video spread across Cuba like wildfire, quickly making Ávila a minor celebrity. Moreover, had the *paquete* existed at the time, such an overtly political video would never have passed the self-censorship test routinely applied today by the *paquete*'s compilers. But that does not mean it would have remained unknown. 24

Nieves Cárdenas points out that a similar "virality" occurred after the August 2017 leaking of a closed-door speech given by Cuban first vice president Miguel Díaz-Canel to Communist Party cadres in which he condemns a number of independent media start-ups and think tanks by name and justifies their censorship and closure.[25] "The leaked video of Díaz-Canel," notes Nieves Cárdenas, "that type of content has *never* been included in the *paquete*. The *paquete*

sin necesidad de tener Internet, con correos electrónicos de Nauta, correos de Infomed o correos incluso de G-mail si el usuario quisiera, se puede actualizar. Esto quiere decir que usando las redes institucionales, usando Nauta un usuario puede mandar un correo y recibirá un correo de vuelta que la aplicación le mostrará nuestros artículos."

[24] The various versions of this video available on YouTube have together received well over a million views as of June 2019. See here for one short clip: https://www.youtube.com/ watch?v=vgj3gPbLE4g. "Cuba: preguntas difíciles al gobierno, difíciles respuestas," February 6, 2008, posted by PepitosGroup, 4:14). Of course, the number of offline views is impossible to know, yet far more important in the Cuban context — especially at that even more disconnected time. In personal communication with the author, Eliécer Ávila described multiple instances of strangers recognizing and thanking him for his brave words as he traveled in small towns and far-flung provinces across Cuba.

[25] A version of this leaked video is available at Nora Gámez Torres, "Miguel Díaz-Canel: 'Cuba no tiene que dar nada a cambio' a EEUU," *El Nuevo Herald*, August 21, 2017, https://www.elnuevoherald.com/noticias/mundo/america-latina/cuba-es/article168492522.html.

censors that kind of thing. But it spreads across practically the entire country, and one way or the other, Cubans found out about it." As the publisher of an independent digital media start-up, Nieves Cárdenas sees a key lesson here that directly affects his distribution strategy:

> What did that tell us? That when the quality of the product is sufficient, it manages to bypass the barriers that censorship itself and even the self-censorship of the *paquete* create. In our case, it has happened especially with videos. Although *El Toque* is blocked in some parts of the *paquet*e, our videos . . . have bypassed that censorship. . . . They were simply distributed . . . from memory to memory, following a virality highly specific to the Cuban context. [Going] from USB to USB, from flash drive to hard drive, or also from phone to phone. Two phones do "Zapya" and content is shared. This has been our first experience, that is: "Betting on quality content guarantees that the content manages to bypass censorship by itself because people understand that the content is very interesting and so share it with other people." [26]

Conclusion: ¿Dentro de la revolución digital?

Ever since Fidel Castro gave his infamous 1961 speech "Words to the Intellectuals," establishing the cryptic but still officially enforced *política cultural* of the Cuban Revolution—"Within the Revolution, everything; against the Revolution, nothing"—Cuba's creative classes have had to proceed with extreme trepidation in their work, never knowing for sure what was clearly within, without, or against the revolution. As a result of this long-standing and perhaps purposely enigmatic "cultural policy," Cuban culture has long been doubly mediated by fear. To paraphrase Cuban writer Antonio Benítez-Rojo: first, there is the state's fear of the artist, that leads to censorship; and then there's the artist's fear of the state results in self-censorship (Benítez Rojo 1990).

This game of fear, censorship, and self-censorship has led to the development of a deep seated *doble moral* (duplicitousness) in Cuban culture, negatively affecting the artistic, intellectual, and journalistic production of those working in Cuba's state-controlled economic and institutional sector. However, it has also cast a shadow over the activities of those—like the digital journalists profiled in this article—who have sought to work independently of (if not necessarily in opposition to) the Cuban state. Indeed, with a few important caveats, the same pair of unwritten rules summarized here can be said to govern the operation, content, and distribution of *el paquete*, forcing independent, investigative journalists working on the island to bypass it to reach Cuban readers. For example, Yoani Sánchez, the founding director of *14ymedio*, explained how what was hoped by many independent Cuban journalists to be a new direct-to-*paquete* distribution strategy, has turned out in practice to be another form of censorship: "All our attempts to appear in *el paquete* have been fruitless based on the premise

[26] Original Spanish: "¿Que nos dijo eso? Que cuando la calidad del producto es suficiente, pues logra hacerle *bypass* a las barreras que cree la propia censura incluso la auto-censura del paquete. En nuestro caso, nos ha pasado especialmente con videos. Aunque la marca del Toque está bloqueada en algunos aspectos del paquete los videos [. . .] han hecho bypass de esa censura. [. . .] Sencillamente, se distribuyó por . . . de memoria en memoria, siguiendo un comportamiento de viralidad muy específica en el contexto cubano. [. . .] de USB en USB, de flash drive a disco duro, o también de teléfono a teléfono. Los teléfonos hacen Zapya y se comparte un contenido. Esta ha sido nuestra experiencia primero, o sea: "Apostar por contenido de calidad garantiza que el contenido logre hacer por si mismo bypass de la censura porque la gente entiende que es muy interesante y se lo comparte a otras personas."

that [the distributors] can protect themselves more if they refuse to include material that would bother officialdom. They prefer amusement to reflection on current Cuban issues."[27]

This frustration is shared by José Jasán Nieves Cárdenas, the founding director of *El Toque*, who echoes Sánchez's assessment of the unfortunate content and scope of the *paquete*: "[There is] a lot of material [in *el paquete*] that seeks to entertain, a lot of commercial material aimed at selling products, and very little serious and rigorous journalism from Cuba and for Cuba with an understanding of the informational needs of the Cuban audience."[28]

As has been chronicled here, easily the best known and most widely used example of the Cuban digital *invento* (inventiveness) that characterizes digital life on the island is *el paquete*, a highly efficient, islandwide data-distribution system that has been called Cuba's "largest private employer" by some (Rodríguez 2015; Press 2015a), a "jailbreak [of] the World Wide Web" by others (Fenton 2016), and a "DIY Internet revolution" by still others (García Martínez 2017).[29] To put it more simply, for the vast majority of Cubans, even in the post-3G environment that started in Cuba in December 2018, the *paquete* is the internet (Cobo 2018). While the *paquete* has become Cuba's most popular and easily accessible offline alternative for accessing music, movies, TV series, mobile-phone apps, magazines, and classifieds (San Pedro 2015; Rodríguez 2015; Kessler 2015), the routine self-censorship practiced by its compilers against the content of a host of independent digital media start-ups that practice independent investigative journalism has forced these emergent media outlets to develop multiple, alternative, online and offline content distribution strategies to reach Cuban readers on the island.

The *paquete* has been portrayed in the international media as something rebellious and subversive, a tool of "liberation technology" perhaps (Harris 2015; Kwong 2016). However, the Cuban government is well aware of its existence and has long deployed an unofficial policy of strategic toleration, given that its compilers engage in a policy of strict self-censorship of political—especially dissident or so-called counterrevolutionary—content. Indeed, the state likely appreciates its existence, as the famed sneakernet satisfies its consumers' entertainment needs in ways that the state media system is either unwilling or unable to do. Thus satisfied, Cubans will presumably be "less likely to press for open Internet access," in the assessment of Larry Press. "Had he been writing today in Cuba," Press (2015a) facetiously continues, "Karl Marx would have said that not religion, but '*el paquete* is the opium of the masses.'"

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[27] Despite the vast difference in editorial content between *14ymedio* and *La Joven Cuba*, this is exactly the same dilemma pointed out to me by Harold Cárdenas and highlighted in the article by Dolores Ibárruri. Original Spanish: "Todos los intentos de aparecer en el Paquete han resultado infructuosos bajo la premisa de que se preservan mucho de no difundir contenido que moleste al oficialismo. Prefieren el divertimento a la reflexión sobre temas actuales cubanos."

[28] Original Spanish: "[Hay] mucha información puesta en función de entretenimiento, mucha información comercial en función de la venta de productos y muy poca información de periodismo serio y riguroso hecho desde Cuba para Cuba y entendiendo necedades informativas de la audiencia cubana."

[29] Díaz Torres notes the *paquete*'s growing economic dimension given that "it has become a significant source of informal employment for thousands of people who work in the distribution of the hard drives or in final sales to consumers." He also notes that in recent years (2017–2019) commercial ads for all kinds of digital products (software, apps, and updates) have begun to appear in the *paquete*. According to him, an inventive payment system has developed for these *alegal* transactions whereby the buyer sends a cell-phone credit equal to the agreed-on price to the seller's phone. Upon receipt of the credit, the seller then sends the buyer a text message containing the necessary password to unlock the digital product, thus finalizing the transaction (personal communication).

Between 2014 and 2019, Cuba witnessed the appearance of more than a dozen nonstate, "independent" or "alternative" digital media platforms covering a broad, diverse spectrum of themes from a variety of professional and political viewpoints. This grassroots, citizen-led "indie media" phenomenon deepened and broadened during these years reaching an ever-greater portion of the Cuban public on the island, despite a continued government policy of severe restrictions on—and indeed routine repression of—any media outlets not controlled by the Communist Party (Freedom House 2018). While the government still holds a monopoly on the mass media—especially printed matter and television—it has lost that position in the digital sphere thanks to both the *paquete* and the many, diverse digital projects and their innovative content distribution strategies.

Now that more and more Cubans are going online, they are increasingly able to access many of these sites, which makes the sites' impact even greater. This recent surge in the number of independent digital media sites has developed together with an increase in their reliability, credibility, and professionalism—qualities that have in turn forced state-controlled media to make internal changes to try to compete. Not all independent digital outlets consider themselves dissident operations, but most struggle to survive between the government's open repression of independent journalists and the lack of a legal framework that would protect them. A notable characteristic of many of these emergent sites is that they are staffed not by political dissidents (as was the case of Cuba's independent media for many years) but by young graduates from the various journalism programs at Cuban universities who refuse to work for the official media but work as professional journalists at these newly founded independent sites. In sum, Cuba's independent digital journalism sites have been both innovative and impactful, covering issues omitted in the official press, experimenting with new genres and formats, and diversifying content distribution strategies to function in Cuba's peculiar hybrid online-offline digital context (Díaz 2018).

Notes

Samuel Farber, Harold Cárdenas, Larry Press, Isbel Díaz Torres, Armando Chaguaceda, and an anonymous reviewer each provided valuable feedback on an earlier version of this article. Additionally, writing this article would have been impossible without the collaboration of the founding editors of many of Cuba's indie start-up digital media sites, most of whom are named in this article.

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